1644).

Though the Song dynasty inaugurated an era of Chinese maritime power and expanded ocean-borne trade, such trade had been taking place in the preceding centuries too, but was in the hands of mainly Persian, Indian and later Arab traders, who conducted the trade through the Chinese ports of Guangzhou in Guangdong province, Quanzhou in Fujian province and Nanjing. Chinese merchants generally handled the transhipment of imported goods into the Chinese hinterland or brought Chinese goods to the ports for the same foreign traders to export to various foreign markets. Chinese merchants stayed close to their own coasts or travelled only as far as the entrepot ports of Funan and later to those in South-East Asia, such as Palembang in Sumatra and Malacca in Malaya.

It was during the Song period that the Chinese themselves began to compete and in some ways dominate long-distance maritime trade. Chinese ports developed into major commercial centres and hosted several resident communities of foreign traders. The trade between India and China remained a large component of this maritime trade. Various routes were used for such shipments, and important shifts took place in these routes over the years.

In the early years of the first millennium, India–China trade used the transit ports of Oc-Eo in Funan and those further north in Jiaozhi, in present-day Vietnam. Another important route traversed the kingdom of Siam (present-day Thailand) and ports on the Myanmar (Burma) coast. The old Siamese capital of Ayutthia (named after the ancient Indian city of Ayodhya) became an important transit port where Chinese silk and porcelain would be exchanged for Indian cotton, spices, and Buddhist relics and ritual items. From Ayutthia, goods travelled overland to the port cities on the narrow Kra isthmus such as present-day Mergui on Myanmar’s Tenasserim coast. From Mergui, goods would be shipped to ports on the Coromandel and Malabar coasts. Another route went through Myanmar to the port of Martaban on the Bay of Bengal, from where goods would be transhipped to ports on the Bengal and Odisha (Orissa) coasts such as Tamralipti, or Tamluk.